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Report details low wages at nail salons

Survey reveals Mass. workers suffer from asthma, headaches caused by chemicals

By Katie Johnston
GLOBE STAFF

People get their nails done to add a little glamour to their lives. But the workers applying polish across the table from them are often focused on surviving.

A recent survey of nail technicians in Massachusetts found that the majority earn less than $40,000 a year giving manicures and pedicures, with wide seasonal fluctuations in income, according to a report released Monday by the Massachusetts Nail Salon Project, an advocacy coalition. Many workers suffer from headaches, asthma, or nausea they believe are caused by chemicals they use, but they can be reluctant to wear face masks to protect themselves because clients don't like it. Racial discrimination by clients is also an issue.

This volatile industry has long attracted Asian women who speak little English and are in need of jobs with a low barrier to entry, putting them at the intersection of social justice issues involving race, class, gender, and health.

In Massachusetts, the workforce is primarily made up of low-income Vietnamese women who are often overlooked by society, according to the Vietnamese American Initiative for Development and its partner organizations. Language access and working-class backgrounds — especially among those whose families came to the United States as refugees — make them less likely to push back against difficult conditions.

There are more than 18,000 licensed technicians working at roughly 1,700 registered salons across the state, according to the report, which builds on a small survey of Vietnamese nail salon workers in 2021 focused on pandemic-related challenges.

The new research didn't reveal the kind of exploitation detailed in a 2015 New York Times investigation that found new workers who had to pay salon owners for their spots and worked without pay for months. But Massachusetts can take steps to improve income stability and working conditions, which will help trans-

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SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

'The potential to transform cancer care across our region'

Dana-Farber, Beth Israel kick off construction of $1.68 billion hospital



PAT GREENHOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

At top, hospital leaders, donors, and elected officials broke ground on the new hospital Monday. Anne Gross of Dana-Farber (above) said leaders spent more than a year designing the future hospital rooms.

By Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

Officials at Dana-Farber Cancer Institute and Beth Israel Lahey Health celebrated on Monday the start of work on their new $1.68 billion Boston hospital to treat cancer patients, the only medical center of its kind in New England.

The clanking of cranes slated to descend over the Longwood site also brings the impending divorce of Dana-Farber and its longtime partner, Brigham and Women's Hospital, one step closer. Meanwhile, Brigham's parent, Mass General Brigham, has launched its own rival cancer institute and is constructing new buildings and renovating other spaces to compete.

"We've been talking about it an enormous amount, what the hospital will mean, what we will be able to accomplish with a cancer-focused hospital," said Dr. Benjamin Ebert, Dana-Farber's chief executive. "But seeing the construction and really imagining what it's going to look like and what we're going to be able to do is motivating."

The 300-bed, 450,000-square-foot hospital is set to open in 2031 for patients who need inpatient care during treatment. It will sit on the site of the former Joslin Diabetes Center on Brookline Avenue.

HOSPITAL, Page A6

Medford hire raises concerns over vetting

Teacher had resigned amid allegations of sex with a student in Florida

By John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

Medford Public Schools was proud of its newest hire: An August 2024 press release announced that longtime Florida educator Michael Dampier would teach high school music and lead the Mustangs' marching band.

Then-superintendent Marice Edouard-Vincent gushed about Dampier in her blog, writing that she looked forward "to seeing (and hearing!)" him work with students and "enhance Medford's proud performances in the arts."

But in hiring Dampier, Medford school officials missed a key fact: He had resigned from a teaching job in Florida nearly a decade ago while under investigation for having a sexual relationship with a 16-year-old student — something they would likely have uncovered with a simple phone call to his prior employer.

It was even covered in local media at the time.

Dampier taught Medford students for 16 months until an anonymous email in February alerted school officials of his past. His case raises questions about whether schools do enough to vet teachers before they step into a classroom.

"Most people who run these schools think that if the applicant passes [a criminal background] check and the fingerprint check, that they are

MEDFORD, Page A7

Testimony on pregnancy in Farwell trial

FBI agent: Birchmore was excited about having a baby

By Nick Stoico
GLOBE STAFF

An FBI agent testified Monday that Sandra Birchmore learned she was pregnant in December 2020 and sent Matthew Farwell a text message announcing the news: "Congrats, we are going to be parents in 2021."

But FBI Special Agent Heidi Kelsch later testified under cross-examination that a paternity test identified the father of Birchmore's child as Jason Pickard, an Army recruiter from Quincy. Kelsch said Pickard and Birchmore met around December 2019.

Prosecutors have previously said that DNA testing excluded Farwell as the father of Birchmore's fetus, although they maintain the two were trying to conceive and believed they had done so. Birchmore believed Farwell was the father before she died in February 2021, according to previous court testimony.

The Globe has been unable in multiple past attempts to reach Pickard for comment. His name has appeared in legal arguments before, but this is the first time he was identified as the father of

FARWELL, Page A7

File under fabulous

Tuesday: Sun with a breeze. High 58-63. Low 44-49.
Wednesday: Cooler, cloudy. High 50-55. Low 42-47.
Sunrise: 7:03 Sunset: 5:54
Obituaries, **C9**
Comics and Weather, **D5-6**

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Suggested retail price
$4.00

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Michael Minogue, the GOP nominee for governor, sought to distance himself further from his one-time running mate Shawn Oliver, hours after Oliver pleaded not guilty to drunken driving charges. **B1.**

Republicans have a huge cash advantage in the midterm elections, but spending is focusing on Senate, not House, races. **A2.**

European cities have become platforms of protest as several top EU economies, including France, Italy, and Spain, approach pivotal elections. **A3.**

Chelsea-based Kayem Foods Inc., known for its Fenway Franks, issued a voluntary recall of more than 1.5 million pounds of hot dogs, sausages, bacon, and other products over problems with a cooler. **D1.**

Grounds for dismissal

Starbucks used to be a city fixture. Now its retreat prompts questions.

By Alexa Gagosz
GLOBE STAFF

It's not yet 9 a.m. on a recent weekday, and the last Starbucks standing in downtown Boston is slammed.

More than 40 coffees are lined up on the counter waiting to be claimed by customers who ordered on their phones. Baristas are scrambling to keep up, calling out a procession of drinks — cold foam this, nondairy milk that — as office workers crowd into the cramped café. Wedged between the tourist crush of Faneuil Hall and the towers of Boston's Financial District, the shop is struggling to keep pace. Wait times for a single drink are stretching beyond half an hour.

For years, Starbucks was a fixture of downtown Boston, with locations scattered across its busiest blocks. Now, a wave of closures has left customers crowding into the city center's last outpost — at 84 State St. — while some former stores sit vacant in prime commercial real estate. The result is a bottleneck for customers and a striking symbol of the coffee giant's retreat.

STARBUCKS, Page A10



MELECK ELDAHSHOURY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

A store on State Street is Starbucks' sole survivor in downtown Boston.